



Defending *your turf*

WARNING SIGNS

The risks involved in fighting can be costly for an animal, so most try a variety of tactics first to ward off their enemies.

WHY FIGHT?

There are a number of reasons why animals fight: to defend their territory, to get a share of any food, to gain access to mates, or to protect their young. Fighting is dangerous and can lead to injury or even death. But it does have an evolutionary benefit—the strongest survive to pass their genes on to future generations.



**STAY
AWAY!**

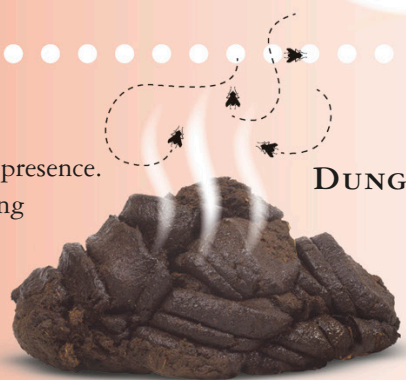
Making the call

Territory is often declared using calls. Birds have key perches from which they send out loud, noisy songs that tell others to keep off their turf. In the rainforest, troops of monkeys and gibbons call out to other teams that might be in the area to make sure they stay away from their trees.

HOWLER MONKEY

What's that smell?

Scent marking is another way that animals announce their presence. Many animals have glands on the body that produce a strong odor. By rubbing against trees and bushes they leave their smell behind. Urine and droppings are also used to mark boundaries. Smells act as warnings to their own species and to others—it pays to know if a predator is around.



DUNG

INTO BATTLE

There comes a point where you have to engage the enemy. Even then it is rarely a fight to the death. Instead there may be a few tentative charges as the opponents assess each other's strengths. Most fights involve biting, kicking, and wrestling. They usually end when the weaker animal realizes that it hasn't got a chance of winning and signals that it is giving up.

